

Fury Unleashed!

A brawl between the fastest cards from ATI and NVIDIA

We have the all new GTX 260 with the Zotac overclocked badge—Amp! just like the GTX 280 we received last month. ATI's newly launched Radeon 4870 from ASUS and the smaller 4850 from Palit are also here. Other than these new launches, we also have two GeForce GTX280 cards—one from Gigabyte and an overclocked XXX edition from XFX.

All the cards from all the brands arrived in their standard clothing—no special coolers or fans on either of the cards. The 4850 was the thinnest of all the cards and the only one to consume only a single slot.

The Palit Radeon 4850 was small in comparison but the cooling solution that comes on the card was not enough to cool it sufficiently. We recorded tem-



XFX GeForce GTX 280 XXX Edition

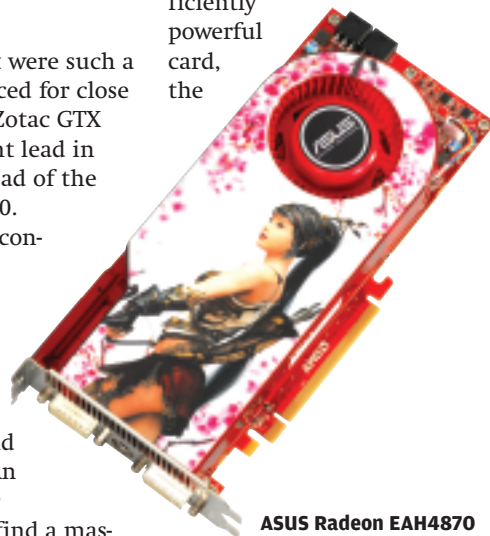
peratures of over 80 C with the air conditioner set to 22 C. The fan and the cooler design are different from the 4870 and the speed of the fan is also quite slow. All the other cards were also quite hot but not as much as the 4850. ATI has been addressing these issues through their drivers and temporary solutions are being released by tech communities.

The GTX 280s shone through all the tests absolutely destroyed the

8800 GTX's that were such a dominating forced for close to 2 years. The Zotac GTX 260 had a decent lead in all the tests ahead of the ATI Radeon 4870.

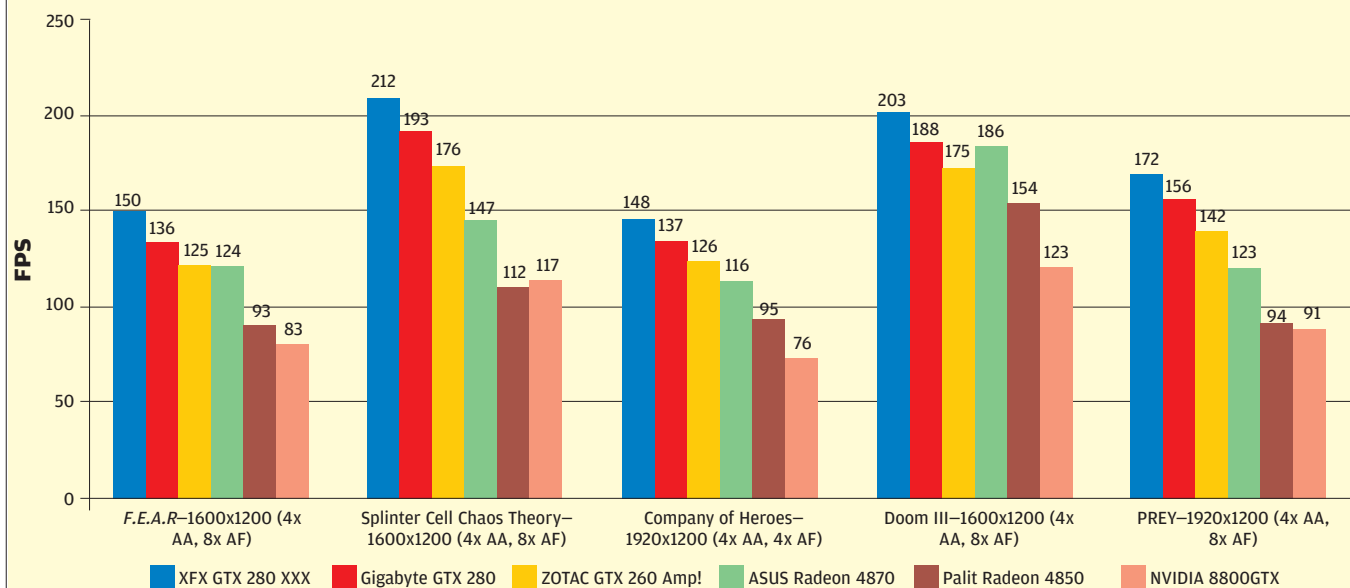
Our biggest concern is the Palit Radeon 4850. It is a small card, runs extremely hot but matches the 8800GTX and the 9800 GTX. An 8800GT user for example won't find a mas-

sive difference if he switches to the 4850. This card falls into the upper mid range category of yesterday and it is most likely to end up in a system that runs all the time. If we are to go just by performance, then if you don't own a sufficiently powerful card, the



ASUS Radeon EAH4870

Benchmarks



4850 is worth considering. The 9800 GTX is also worth considering as the prices it have been slowly been subsidizing with the release of the new cards.

As for the best performers today, the GTX 280 still continue to reign. The XFX GTX 280 XXX Edition's performance in all the tests was identical to the overclocked Zotac GTX 280 we received last month. The XFX card however is more expensive than Zotac. There is no single card in the market today that's more powerful than the GTX 280. One has to remember that NVIDIA has made huge price cuts and those are expected to be reflected soon in Indian markets.

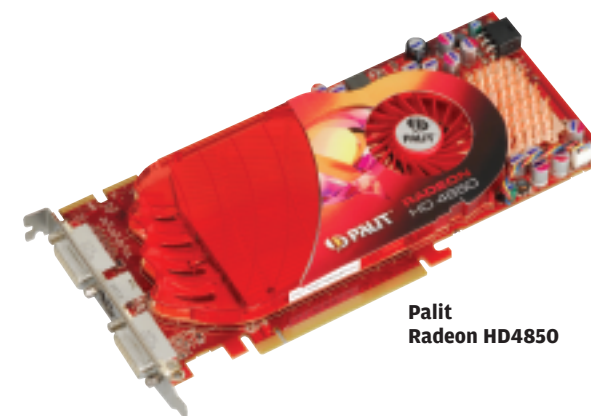
We talked about the performance of the Zotac GTX 260 Amp! and it is only a little more than Rs 2,500 costlier than the ASUS Radeon 4870. The choice between the two is a little difficult. The Zotac GTX 260 Amp! does outperform the 4870 in most of the games by some 10-30 fps. The performance of the Radeon 4870 is not consistent in all the games. For example, there are occasions when the Radeon 4870 even chal-

lenges the Gigabyte GTX 280 in Doom III. If you have the extra Rs 2,000, the Zotac GTX 260 Amp! is a good buy but if you don't, then the Radeon 4870 is still a really good card to buy and will run pretty much all the games with max quality at 1920 x 1200 resolution at a very comfortable frame rate.

This isn't the aftermath of a huge battle and things could change pretty quickly as there is a good possibility of the 4870x2 cards from ATI showing up soon. There is also another way to look at things—all the games out today, with the exception of a few games like *Crysis* of course, run perfectly fine on cards of the calibre of the GeForce 8800GT or the 9600GT at a resolution of 1600x1200 with the details turned up to maximum. That means there is no real need as such for people to upgrade to any of these cards. Even the cheapest of the cards we've tested today—the Radeon 4850 that runs a new game like *Unreal Tournament 3* at 1920x1200 at maximum quality at 86 fps!



Zotac GeForce GTX 260 Amp! Edition



Palit Radeon HD4850



Gigabyte GeForce GTX 280

RATINGS

	XFX GeForce GTX 280 XXX Edition	Gigabyte GeForce GTX 280	ZOTAC GeForce GTX 260 Amp! Edition	ASUS Radeon EAH4870	Palit Radeon HD4850
Features	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Value for money	★★★☆☆	★★★☆☆	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★★

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Price	Rs 49,000	Rs 49,425	Rs 23,500	Rs 21,350	Rs 12,000